

Stealing Search Engine Queries with JavaScript

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Stealing Search Engine Queries with JavaScript

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Stealing Search Engine Queries with JavaScript

By: SPI Labs

SPI Labs has expanded on existing techniques and discovered a practical method of using JavaScript to detect the search queries a user has entered into arbitrary search engines. As seen with the recent leakage of 36 million search queries made by half a million American Online subscribers, there are enormous privacy concerns when a users search queries are made public. All the code needed to steal a users search queries is written in JavaScript and uses Cascading Style Sheets (CSS). This code could be embedded into any website either by the website owner or by a malicious third party through a Cross-site Scripting (XSS) attack. There it would harvest information about every visitor to that site. For example, an HMOs website could check if a visitor has been searching other sites about cancer, cancer treatments, or drug rehab centers. Advertising networks could gather information about which topics someone is interested based on their search history and use that to enhance their customer databases. Government websites could see if a visitor has been searching for bomb-making instructions.

** Key features of this research brief: **

- Understand how JavaScript can be used to steal queries from a search engine
- Learn the real world scenarios for this vulnerability.
- Specific recommendations for developers to protect themselves from this threat
- [Click here to view the entire article](#)

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